Michelle Layvant

Department of Agricultural and Resource Economics, University of California, Berkeley

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Education

University of California, Berkeley 2021–present
Ph.D. Candidate in Agricultural and Resource Economics

University of California, Berkeley 2012–2015
B.A. in Economics, Minor in Public Policy

Research Fields

Primary: Development Economics **Secondary:** Labor Economics, Behavioral Economics

References

Edward Miguel
Dept. of Economics
University of California, Berkeley
emiguel@berkeley.edu

Jeremy Magruder
Dept. of Agricultural and Resource Economics
University of California, Berkeley
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Dmitry Taubinsky
Dept. of Economics
University of California, Berkeley
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Gautam Rao
Haas School of Business & Dept. of Economics
University of California, Berkeley
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Job Market Paper

Committed to Education: School Fees, Vouchers, and the Timing of Cash Transfers
with Gonzalo Ferres Available here.

Abstract. Primary-school dropout remains widespread in Sub-Saharan Africa, and school fees are seen as a major barrier to completion. In an experiment with 2,000 parents and children in Uganda, we study whether time inconsistency contributes to unpaid school fees and lower school participation. We first elicit parents willingness to pay for two restrictions on a cash transfer: (1) delaying it until fees are due and (2) earmarking it as a voucher paid directly to the school, holding timing fixed. Demand for both restrictions is substantial: 62 percent of parents are willing to pay for delay and 69 percent for earmarking. We then randomly assign parents to three treatment arms and a control group. The three arms provide the same amount as cash six weeks before fees are due, as cash when fees are due, or as a voucher, and the control group receives no transfer. The voucher more than doubles fees paid, increases school attendance, and cuts within-term dropout by more than half. Cash has smaller effects on all three outcomes, with no additional effect from delayed cash over early cash. Perhaps surprisingly, the vouchers effects on fee payment and attendance are largest among parents with low willingness to pay for it, in part because they substantially underestimate how much it will raise their fee payment relative to cash. In a model of quasi-hyperbolic discounting, these findings are consistent with partial naïveté, in which parents anticipate their own time inconsistency but underestimate its severity.

Working Papers

Impacts of Secondary School in Kenya after Two Decades
with Edward Miguel, Owen Ozier, and Michael Walker Available here.

Abstract. This paper studies the long-run effects of access to secondary school in Kenya – where admission depended on a cutoff score on a national exam – using a regression discontinuity design and a panel dataset that follows individuals for nearly two decades after the exam. Scoring above the cutoff raises secondary school completion by 18 percentage points, with similar increases for women and men. Greater access to secondary schooling leads to substantial improvements in cognition, with gains of 0.20.3 standard deviations into midlife. Realized fertility also declines substantially and persistently among men (by about 0.8 children on average) but, perhaps surprisingly, not for women. There is suggestive evidence that benefits may extend to the next generation, as the children of female respondents who scored above the exam cutoff perform better on tests of academic skills.

Publications

Walker, M. W., Huang, A. H., Asman, S., Baird, S. J., Fernald, L., Hamory Hicks, J., Hoces de la Guardia, F., Koiso, S., Kremer, M., Krupoff, M. N., **Layvant, M.**, Ochieng, E., Suri, P., and Miguel, E. "Intergenerational Child Mortality Impacts of Deworming: Experimental Evidence from Two Decades of the Kenya Life Panel Survey." *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics*, forthcoming.

Ma, X., **Layvant, M.**, Miguel, E., Ochieng, E., Pillarisetti, A., and Walker, M. W. "Impacts of Contemporaneous Air Pollution Exposure on Cognitive Performance in Kenya." *Journal of Health Economics*, 109:103166, 2026.

Gross, A. L., Duhon, M., Ochieng, E., Ikanga, J. N., Dow, W. H., Lee, J., Walker, M. W., **Layvant, M.**, Ngugi, A., Ehrlich, J. R., and Miguel, E. A. "Midlife Cognitive Testing in Africa: Validity of the Harmonised Cognitive Assessment Protocol in the Kenya Life Panel Survey." *BMJ Open*, 15(8), 2025.

Grants and Fellowships

2026

Giannini Foundation of Agricultural Economics	$35,000
Rocca Dissertation Fellowship, UC Berkeley Center for African Studies	$11,000
John L. Simpson ABD Fellowship, UC Berkeley	$1,000

2025

Development Challenge Awards, Center for Effective Global Action (two awards)	$12,150; $12,000

2024

Learning for All, Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab (J-PAL)	$60,768
The Weiss Fund, University of Chicago	$39,498
CEDA Pilot Grant, Center on the Economics and Demography of Aging	$28,400
Development Challenge Award, Center for Effective Global Action	$15,000
John L. Simpson ABD Fellowship, UC Berkeley	$10,000

2023

Gender Economics Research Award, UC Berkeley Economics	$9,000

Teaching

University of California, Berkeley

Business and Production of Beer, Wine, and Spirits	2021–23, 2025–26
Population, Environment, and Development	2024
Case Studies in Economic Development	2023

Research Assistance

University of California, Berkeley

Graduate Research Assistant to Edward Miguel	present
Undergraduate Research Assistant to David Card	2014–2015

Partners In Health

Pro-Bono Researcher	2016–2020

Professional Experience

Senior Research Associate, Center for Effective Global Action, UC Berkeley 2019–2021

Senior Analyst, Analysis Group, San Francisco 2016–2019

Presentations

UC Berkeley: Development Lunch (2024–2026, multiple presentations), Development Workshop (2023–2026, multiple presentations), Development Department Seminar (2026), Labor Department Seminar (2026), Agricultural and Resource Economics Department Seminar (2026)

Other: CEGA Research Retreat (2026), Economic Science Association (2026), CEGA Evidence Action Summit (2024), Population Association of America (2024), CEGA Working Group in African Political Economy (2023), CEDA Aging in Africa (2022)

Service to the Profession

Mentoring: East Africa Social Science Translation Collaborative, UC Berkeley (Spring 2023, Fall 2023)